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THE QUESTION OF HOW TO IMPLEMENT THE NAVAL BLOCKADE of Cuba without causing a Soviet-American war moved to the top of President Kennedy's agenda on October 23, the day after his television address. That morning he transformed his informal group of advisers on the Cuban missile crisis into the Executive Committee of the National Security Council, or ExCom.

The first meeting of ExCom began at 10:00 a.m. on Tuesday, October 23. "There was a certain spirit of lightness—not gaiety certainly, but a feeling of relaxation, perhaps," wrote Robert Kennedy, recalling the atmosphere in the White House Cabinet Room. "We had taken the first step, it wasn't so bad, and we were still alive." The official Soviet statement transmitted by TASS that morning announced that the Soviet Army command had canceled the planned demobilization of conscripts, but there was no news of planned military actions. McGeorge Bundy called the Soviet statement a "rehash of stuff we've heard before." Dean Rusk was relieved: "We've passed the one contingency: an immediate, sudden, irrational strike." The Soviets seemed to be on the defensive. Washington knew nothing about the nuclear submarines approaching the island.[2]

The first to report that morning was the CIA director, John McCone. On the new batch of photos taken by U-2 pilots, his photography experts could not locate the Soviet missiles they had seen there earlier. Regrettably, this was not an indication that Khrushchev had listened to Kennedy and was removing the missiles from the island. McCone pointed to evidence of "extensive camouflage." The Soviets were not removing but hiding their missiles from view. "It was never clear why they waited until that late date to do so," recalled Robert Kennedy, describing the thoughts of those in the room. "We caught them without their contingency [plan]," said Deputy Undersecretary of State for Political Affairs Alexis Johnson, not without satisfaction.[3]

According to Robert Kennedy, "the relaxed lighter mood had completely disappeared" in the room when the ExCom began discussing American contingency plans in case of a Soviet military response either in Cuba, or, as John Kennedy feared, in West Berlin. As McNamara reported on the possible response to a potential shooting down of a U-2 plane by a